

RICHMOND'S ISABELLE CHEN WINS GOLD AT CANADIAN TRIALS — AND SHE'S ALREADY CHANGING THE GAME AT HOME

The 17-year-old wrestler, youth leader, and City of Richmond award recipient won gold at the 2026 Canadian World Team Trials — and is asking her community to support her competitive season, including a potential appearance at the World Championship in Azerbaijan this July



RICHMOND, BC — In late May, Isabelle Chen traveled to Montreal and came home as a **Canadian World Team Trials gold medalist**. The 17-year-old freestyle wrestler, competing in the 49 kg U17 Cadet category, delivered one of the strongest performances of her career — and is now awaiting the final selection decision that could send her to the 2026 World Championship in Azerbaijan this July.

Representing Canada at the world level runs in the family. Her father, Chef Alex Chen, competed at the Bocuse d'Or in Lyon, France in 2013 — the most prestigious culinary competition in the world — and finished in the top 10. In 2025, he returned to Lyon as a jury member, representing Canada on the international stage once again. This summer, it is Isabelle's turn.

For those who know Isabelle, the result was not a surprise. What she has accomplished on the mat is only part of her story.



left: Isabelle (bottom) and her high school wrestling team in 2024; right: Isabelle and her Richmond wrestling team in 2026

A LEADER ON AND OFF THE MAT

In 2024, Isabelle recognized a simple problem: she didn't have enough training partners or mat time. Rather than accept that as a limitation, she started a wrestling team at Hugh Boyd Secondary School. She was the only female wrestler on the roster — and she was named team captain.

That was just the beginning. In the 2025–2026 season, Isabelle and her teammates from Bhullar Wrestling Club grew the program beyond Hugh Boyd, expanding to four additional high schools across Richmond. What started as one girl looking for more mat time has become a movement. And she is not done — Isabelle is now setting her sights on bringing wrestling into Richmond's elementary schools, building a foundation for the next generation of athletes before they even reach high school.

That instinct — to create opportunity rather than wait for it — runs through everything she does. Isabelle is a member of *Canada's Generation 2026 Youth Leadership Council*, where she works to promote equity and representation in sport. She mentors younger wrestlers, advocates for girls' access to athletic spaces, and leads by example both on and off the mat.

In April 2026, the City of Richmond recognized her contributions with the *U-ROC Youth Leadership Award* — an honour that reflects not just what she has achieved, but the kind of person she is choosing to be.

Her message to young girls is clear: every girl deserves access, opportunity, and a sense of belonging — on and off the mat. No one should have to wait for permission to step into the arena. Isabelle doesn't just say it. She proves it.

"Every girl deserves access, opportunity, and a sense of belonging on and off the mat. My goal is to make sure no one feels like they have to wait for permission to step into the arena."

— ISABELLE CHEN, 2026 CANADIAN WORLD TEAM TRIALS GOLD MEDALIST



Isabelle received the U-ROC Youth Leadership award from the City of Richmond

A FULL SEASON AHEAD

Regardless of what the coming weeks bring, Isabelle's competitive season is far from over. She has developmental training camps and tournaments ahead that are critical to her growth as an elite athlete — and if the final selection decision goes her way, she will also be representing Canada at the 2026 World Championship in Azerbaijan at the end of July.

Like many amateur athletes in Canada, the cost of competing at the highest level falls largely on the athlete and her family. Training camps, travel, accommodation, and competition fees add up quickly — and none of it pauses while selection decisions are made. Isabelle is working to raise \$10,000 to fund her full competitive season, and she is asking her community to help make it possible.

HOW TO SUPPORT ISABELLE

There are several ways to get behind Isabelle as she prepares to represent Canada on the world stage:

Donate directly — Contributions of any size go directly toward Isabelle's training camp and World Championship costs. Her goal is to raise \$10,000.

Donate: <https://gofund.me/e89acf8aa>

Become a sponsor — Businesses and organizations are invited to partner with Isabelle as an official sponsor. Sponsors will have their logo displayed on her team apparel at the World Championship in Azerbaijan, placing their brand alongside a Richmond athlete competing for Canada.

Sponsorship inquiries: eow@chefalexchen.com

Support Her — One Jar at a Time

If you are looking for a more delicious way to show your support, Isabelle also runs her own small food business: Miss Chen Kaya. She handcrafts pandan-flavoured coconut jam — a beloved Southeast Asian spread — and a portion of proceeds goes directly toward her training and competition fund.

Miss Chen Kaya is available for purchase at www.misschenkaya.com. Every jar sold is another step toward her goals.

Isabelle has put in the work. She has earned her place. Now she is asking her community to rally behind her — not just for what she will do in Azerbaijan, but for what she is already doing here at home.



ABOUT ISABELLE CHEN

Isabelle Chen is a 17-year-old competitive freestyle wrestler from Richmond, British Columbia, competing in the 49 kg U17 Cadet category. She is the 2026 Canadian World Team Trials Gold Medalist and is a candidate for selection to represent Canada at the 2026 World Championship in Azerbaijan in late July 2026.

In 2024, Isabelle founded the wrestling program at Hugh Boyd Secondary School — serving as its only female wrestler and team captain. By 2025–2026, she and her Bhullar Wrestling Club teammates had expanded the program to four additional Richmond high schools. She is currently working to bring wrestling into Richmond elementary schools. Isabelle is also a member of Canada's Generation 2026 Youth Leadership Council and the recipient of the 2026 U-ROC Youth Leadership Award from the City of Richmond. She is a committed advocate for equity and access in women's sport.

Her fundraising goal is \$10,000 to cover her full competitive season, including developmental training camps, tournaments, and potentially the 2026 World Championship in Azerbaijan. She also runs Miss Chen Kaya, a small business selling handcrafted pandan-flavoured coconut jam, with proceeds supporting her athletic fund. Miss Chen Kaya is available at www.misschenkaya.com.

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